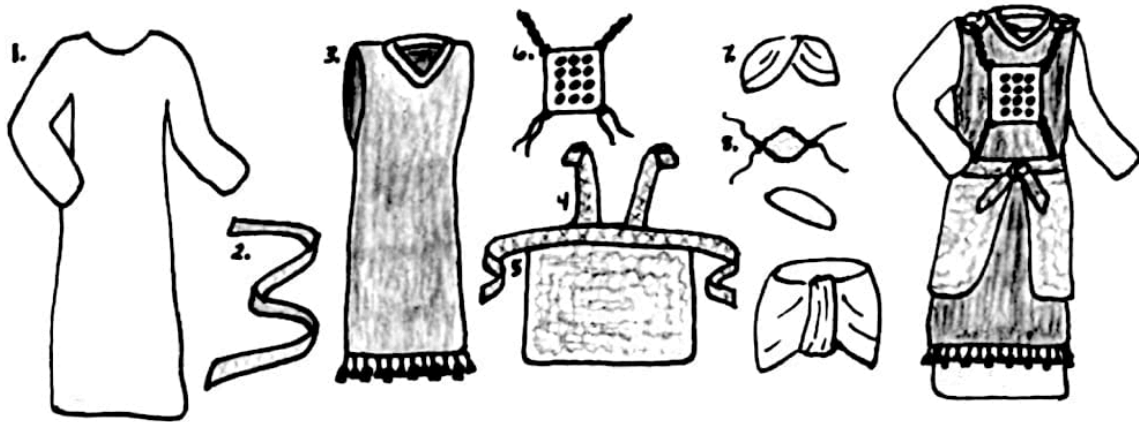


Session 24: Priestly Garments

Key Takeaways

- Aaron and his sons become integrally involved with every aspect of tabernacle worship.
- The high priest's garments function as an inside-out tabernacle.
- The special furniture, garments, and all of the rituals involved with tabernacle life work together to tell the story of God moving into the neighborhood.

Function of the Priestly Garments



Priestly Garments. Drawing by Carmen Imes. Imes, Carmen Joy (2018). *Bearing YHWH's Name at Sinai.* Eisenbrauns. 125.

The priestly garments include a tunic (1), sash (2), robe (3), ephod (4), band (5), breastplate (6), turban (7), and medallion (8).

- Aaron and his sons are part of the cultic apparatus.
- The garments are essential to (constitutive of) their role ([Exod. 28:35](#)).
- The garments imply sacred privilege and responsibility.
- Aaron alone wears colored fabrics (except for the priests' sash).
- Aaron is an "inside-out tabernacle" with his most elaborate garments visible [see Propp, William (2006). [Exodus 19-40](#). 538.].
- Aaron becomes the authorized representative of YHWH and of all 12 tribes, who mediates between them ([Exod. 28:12](#), [29](#)).
- Urim and Thummim facilitate and centralize divine decision making ([Exod. 28:30](#)).
- Aaron bore sanctuary-related sin as the authorized representative ([Exod. 28:38](#)).

Symbolism of the Ordination Ceremony

The ordination ceremony involves all three of the defining marks of a rite of passage: separation, liminality, and reintegration.

- Moses is the primary actor (Aaron and sons are quite passive).
- Blood is an essential symbol of cleansing.
- Priests must first be cleansed before they can facilitate the cleansing of others.
- Sacrifices restore the holiness of the community.
- Blessing initiates the community's vocation as YHWH's representatives.

Reflection Question

How would you describe the role of the high priest? How are the priestly garments crucial to this role?